Part

Creating Texts

Audience

The audience is anyone who reads, views or hears a text. In Section B the task tells you who your audience is, so read that instruction first. Your choice of language, examples, structure and tone all follow from who you think is reading.

Questions to Ask Before You Write

1. What is the piece about, and what does this audience already know about it?
2. What do they care about, and what would make them stop reading?
3. Would they agree with you, disagree, or not care yet?
4. Is there more than one audience, and does one of them matter more?
5. Which existing texts are like this one, and who reads those?

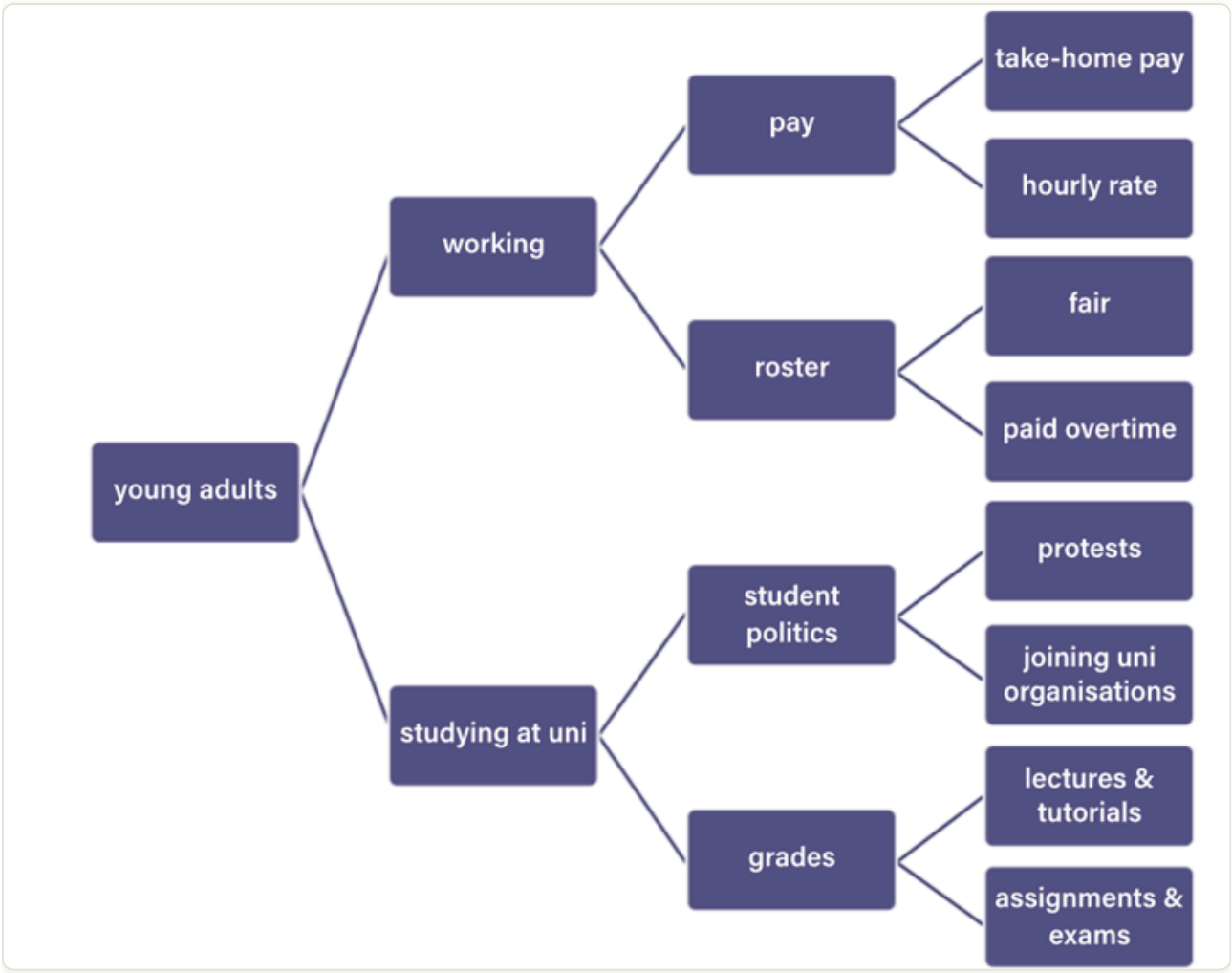
A Worked Example

Suppose the task asks for a piece for a school newspaper about a rule that everyone in your year follows without question. Your audience is classmates, most of whom are not sure the rule is fair. An uncertain reader needs a reason to keep going, so open with something they recognise. Once they trust you, make the argument.

Now suppose the same idea is for a literary magazine. Its readers know short fiction and expect ambiguity. A narrator who explains too much will lose them, so the piece should trust the reader to see what is left unsaid. The subject is the same. The choices are different.

Audience and the Texts

Jackson's 'The Lottery' appeared in *The New Yorker* in 1948, a magazine whose readers were used to stories that did not resolve neatly. Weir made *Picnic at Hanging Rock* for cinema audiences in 1975, who sat in the dark and could not stop the film to ask what had happened. Both texts assume a reader who will work something out for themselves. In the exam, name the audience a text is written for, and show how its choices take that audience into account.



Audience Diagram

Purpose

The study design names four purposes: to **express**, to **explain**, to **reflect** and to **argue**. Strong pieces usually combine more than one, and the purpose should be clear from the writing itself, because in the exam there is no written commentary to explain your intentions. Note that *describing* or *informing* is not one of the purposes. A piece that only describes a protest, a journey, a game or a place has not done the task.

Writing to Express

Expressive writing conveys a feeling, experience or perspective so the reader can share it. It leans on voice, imagery, sensory detail and figurative language. It is the most universal purpose, so on its own it rarely gives a piece direction. Pair it with another.

Writing to Explain

Explaining is often the best place to start planning. You explain the essence of a situation, relationship, problem or difficulty to a reader: a cause and its effect, or a connection between two things. Explanatory writing makes an idea about the Framework clearer to someone who had not considered it.

Writing to Reflect

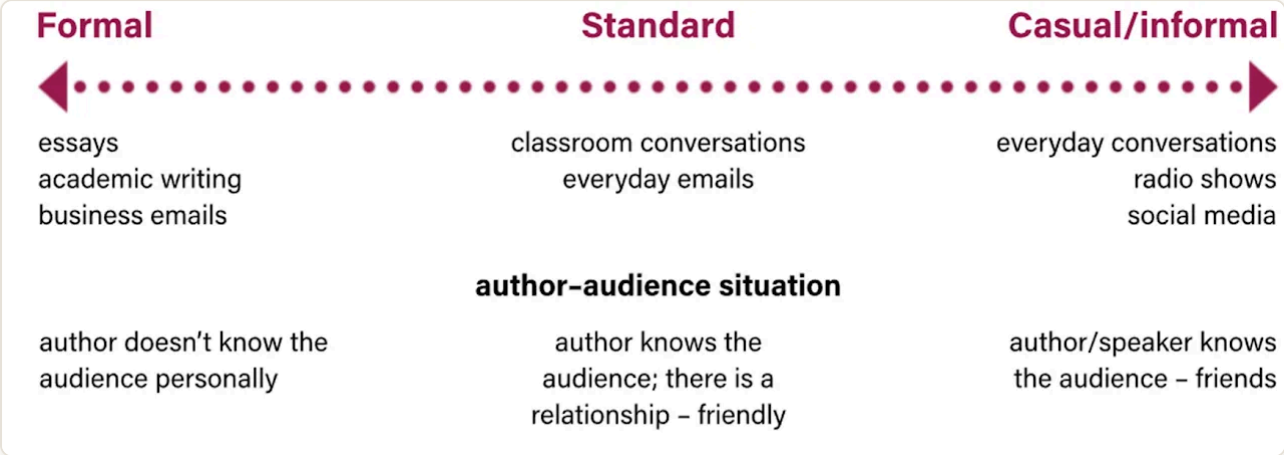
Reflection looks back, whether a minute or a decade, and considers what an experience means now. Hindsight lets the writer analyse how the past shapes the present, which is a powerful way of deepening an idea. Reflective writing tends to move from an experience to an insight.

Writing to Argue

Argument is justification: you sequence reasons to bring a particular audience to a point of view. Audience decides the structure. **If your audience is likely to be uncertain or opposed, hold back your core contention until late in the piece**, after you have built common ground and evidence. If the audience already agrees, you can state it early and focus on mobilising them.

Combining Purposes

Plan purposes as a sequence, not a label. Instead of “to explain”, write “to express an early challenge, then explain how it became a point of growth”. You can sharpen this further by naming your own values as the writer: what do you endorse, criticise or question? Those values become the message the piece builds towards.



Language

Personal Journeys

From the Study Design

Explorations of 'life' or biographical explorations - telling our stories, telling others' stories, the problem of telling stories, appropriation of stories, who tells the stories and our history, missing stories, marginalised and elevated stories. Students could explore personal milestones, the effects of key events on their lives, or explore these ideas through the eyes of others.

Students who have migrated can explore their stories of movement and disruption. They can explore the expectations of change and the language of a new place and culture.

Text type	Good for ...
Blog post	reflecting on a topic
Opinion piece	arguing a point
Short story	telling a story
Poem	expressing emotions
Script	creating a dialogue and narrative
TED Talk	delivering a persuasive speech
Podcast	discussing a topic in an interview
Review	critiquing or analysing a subject
Personal essay	sharing a personal experience
Feature article	exploring a topic in detail

Insight's Different Forms of Text

Writing

- Writing about personal journeys explores both the physical world and the internal world of oneself and others.
- Reading and crafting texts about journeys provide opportunities to consider new places, perspectives, and self-discovery.
- Personal journeys involve various experiences, including challenges, growth, and self-discovery.
- Writing about personal journeys allows individuals to share unique experiences with others.

REMINDER: You have access to the exam generator and the prompt generator to practice your Section B skills.

Ideas

A personal journey can involve:

- Travel to a physical place.
- Psychological or emotional growth and change.
- A combination of both, where physical travel leads to new insights.
- Interior journeys may take a long time to occur due to significant events.
- The most important aspect of a personal journey is change – the individual or group is fundamentally altered by it.

Framework 3: Writing about personal journeys

- Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys.
- You must use the title provided.
- You must use **at least one** of the following stimuli.

Title: 'Finding My Way'

Stimulus 1

'… but it's no use going back to yesterday, because I was a different person then.'

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

'The caterpillar transforms without thought.
Its journey to a beautiful butterfly, inevitable.
Why must my own metamorphosis
Be shaped by so many choices?'

2024 VCAA English Exam - Section B for Personal Journeys

Reading the Framework Inferentially

Read the Framework statement for what it implies, not only what it says. It centres on life writing and storytelling: who tells stories, whose stories are marginalised or elevated, how storytelling gives or takes power, milestones within a longer story, movement and disruption, the familiar and the unfamiliar, expectations of change, and learning the language of a new place.

Build a synonym bank for the Framework's key ideas so no exam title feels unfamiliar. For example: *journey* (passage, odyssey, path, trajectory, pilgrimage); *change* (transition, evolution, metamorphosis, upheaval, growth); *story* (account, testimony, narrative, history, memoir).

Questions worth exploring:

- Why do people feel a need to tell, or uncover, their own story and heritage?
- How does an onlooker see someone else's journey differently from the person living it?
- Are key moments milestones, or millstones that weigh a person down?
- Is the journeying itself as important as what is achieved or lost?
- How do external events open up pathways no one planned?

Guardrails: Personal but Not Private

- **It is the idea of a personal journey, not your autobiography.** A title such as "Finding My Way" is not an invitation to recount your life. It invites ideas about what finding one's way means.
- **Appropriate for an adult stranger.** Your reader is an assessor you will never meet. Avoid content that is overly traumatic, violent or that you would not share with a person in authority. Assessors also have mandatory reporting obligations.
- **Relatable, not alienating.** The goal is a universal human truth the reader can connect with. Something so unique to you that it fosters no empathy works against you.
- **Write as a person, not a student.** Some of the strongest pieces drop the "Year 12 student" identity and write from a human perspective about feelings any reader recognises.

Take the Reader Somewhere: A to B to C

Your piece must itself be a journey. Plan three points:

- **A** - the starting position or understanding;
- **B** - the complication, tension or turning point;
- **C** - the new position: a realisation the reader reaches with you.

Assessors have criticised "stream of consciousness" pieces that wander without milestones. An A-B-C map prevents that and makes your structure visible.

Binaries for Building a Journey

A journey is easiest to see when it moves between opposites. Choose a pair, then find the context that dramatises it:

- familiar → unfamiliar; conformity → individuality
- ignorance → knowledge; uncertainty → clarity
- chaos → order; tension → resolution; pressure → release
- emotion → reason (or the reverse); past → future
- tradition → progress; powerlessness → power; oppression → resistance

Concept First, Then Context

Start with the concept, then find a situation that embodies it, then map the purposes. Example: concept *familiar to unfamiliar*; context *seeing a place you have known all your life from a new angle* (starting work behind the counter of a shop you have visited for years); purposes *express the nerves of the first shift, then explain how seeing the "back room" changed how you see the familiar*. Starting from the concept means you never lose the idea under the story.

Connected or Cohesive?

Mid-band pieces are *connected*: their parts link in sequence like paper dolls holding hands. Top-band pieces are *cohesive*: like a finished jigsaw, every part interlocks to form one picture. Cohesion comes from a single controlling idea (usually drawn from the title), recurring images or motifs, and an ending that resolves the opening.

Building Voice: A Redrafting Exercise

Voice is the personality and perspective that comes through word choice, syntax, punctuation, imagery and tone. Practise it by redrafting a single sentence about an object.

- **Draft 1 (description):** The shoes had a light brown sole and peach-coloured suede. Mum bought them because other students had them.
- **Draft 2 (context and feeling):** Mum came in the front door, arms laden with shopping. I looked past the paper bags to the one I wanted, but the moment I lifted the lid I knew they were the wrong ones: not the ones my friends wore, not the ones that might have let me belong, just a little. My cheeks prickled with ingratitude.
- **Draft 3 (control):** Now move the parts. What changes if the shoes come last, as suspense? If “laden” replaces “full”? If the sentence about belonging is cut short?

The object has become a symbol of belonging, and the voice now carries the idea. Under timed conditions you cannot redraft every line, which is why this practice belongs in the weeks before.

Engaging with the Title and Stimulus

Use your dictionary in reading time. Not because you do not know the words, but to make sure your definition matches the assessor’s, and to find word forms and senses you had not considered. Read the title and every stimulus literally first, then metaphorically (a mountain: height, struggle, vantage, summit; a window: perspective, clarity, separation, opportunity).

Levels of engagement, from mid-band to top-band:

1. The title informs the piece and links it to the Framework.
2. The title and a stimulus are blended to create a new meaning neither had alone.
3. The title and stimulus develop the piece’s purposes and its insight into people and society.
4. The title, stimulus, purpose, audience, context and message all interrelate, moving the reader from A to B to C.

Form, Mentor Texts and Practice

- **Commit to a form and know it intimately.** The question is not which form is best, but whether you have practised it, know its conventions, and whether it suits your purpose and audience.
- **Mentor texts are models, not requirements.** They are not assessed and need not be mentioned. Study how they control structure, carry more than one purpose, and make a personal story feel universal.
- **Write regularly.** Aim for short timed pieces (around 30 minutes) at least twice a week, building up to full 60-minute responses to unseen titles.
- **Get feedback from a reader.** What is clear to you as the writer may not be clear to someone else, so ask a teacher, peer or family member.

Practice Titles

Plan (and then write) responses to these unseen-style titles. Define the title, read it literally and metaphorically, choose a binary, then map A-B-C.

- Finding Joy
- Growth
- Looking Back, Looking Forwards
- I Have Something to Say

Prepare two or three developed ideas before the exam, so on the day you can choose the one that best fits the title.

Sample Personal Journeys Piece: ‘The Spare Key’

Practice stimuli (written for this site, not from an exam): ‘Home is where you leave something behind.’; ‘Keys are the only things we carry from one life into the next.’
For eleven years the spare key to our old house hung on a nail beside the back door of the new one. Nobody told me to keep it. It was simply there one morning, a brass thing with a loose tooth, after Mum had unpacked the last box and I was too tired to ask.

We moved in March. I was nine. The new street had a footpath on one side only, and a dog behind the fence that barked at anyone holding an envelope. Mum said we would be settled by winter. Dad did not say much about it. He drove the van up the hill with the windows down, so the dust from the gravel road came in, and he kept one hand on the dashboard as if the house might slide away behind us.

I did not make friends quickly. At school I learned which corners of the oval were mine and which were not. In the evenings I walked the new streets with the key in my pocket and tried to think of the old house as a place I could still reach. It had a lemon tree that dropped fruit onto the tin roof of the shed. It had a hallway that echoed when you whistled. None of that was in the new house, and I kept waiting for it to appear.

It never did, but the key kept working in my head. Every time someone asked where I was from, I gave the old address, and every time I gave it, I felt slightly less like a stranger in the place I lived now.

I went back on a Saturday when I was twenty. The new owners had painted the front door green. I stood on the path with the key in my hand, and I tried it in the lock out of habit. It did not turn. The lock had been changed years before, and the key was a copy of something that no longer existed.

I put it back in my pocket and walked to the end of the street. A boy was kicking a ball against the fence of the house that used to be ours, and a woman in a dressing gown was watching from the porch. Nobody knew me there. I was glad, in a way, because it meant I could leave without explaining.

The key is still in my drawer. It does not fit anything. I look at it sometimes when I am packing for another move, and I think about how much of a home is just a set of directions you keep carrying after the door has changed.
Why this piece works

- It answers both stimuli without naming them. The key is the object that connects the two ideas, and the journey runs from the old house to the new one and back again.
- The voice stays plain. The sentences are short where the feeling is strong, and the details (the lemon tree, the dog, the green door) carry the emotion without explaining it.
- The ending returns to the object. Revisiting the key gives the piece a shape, which the reader can feel without being told what it means.

Section B Under Exam Conditions

In the SAC you had around 80 minutes, a known prompt, teacher consultation and a written commentary. In the exam you have about 60 minutes, an unseen title, unseen stimuli and no commentary. Everything about purpose, audience and context must come through the writing itself.

A Reading-Time Process

1. Turn only to your own Framework. The other three are a distraction.
2. **Cover the visual stimulus.** Start with the title, because the title, not the image, is the core of the task.
3. Unpack the title: what does it imply? Which aspects of your Framework does it open up?
4. Now read all three stimuli, including the visual. Which one adds a spark that extends, deepens or broadens what the title has suggested?
5. Choose the form and approach you have practised that best suits this title.

Rules and Myths

- **The title is fixed.** You cannot change it or add to it. Write it at the top of your response. If your shaded box and your title disagree, assessors follow the title.
- **Choosing a title chooses its Framework.** No mixing titles, Frameworks or stimulus sets.
- **The title should be threaded through the whole piece**, internalised as its controlling idea. You need not repeat the exact words, though you may.
- **The stimulus is used at least once and interpreted freely.** You may read an image in opposite ways (is the tape being put on, or peeled off?) so long as your reading is clear. Use the *idea* the stimulus generates, not its literal contents: a tree in the image does not require a tree in your piece.

- **More stimuli earn no extra marks.** One, two or three is your choice. There is no correlation between number used and score.
- **There is no preferred form.** Anything except poetry, song or verse, and you may embed a line of poetry or a lyric inside prose.
- **Do not write a story about the Framework.** Narrative elements are fine, but the piece must convey ideas, not just an engaging plot.
- **Crossing out a word to improve it is a strength, not an error.**

Stay on the Framework

The most damaging mistake is a fine piece that has drifted off the Framework. Two common versions:

- **Protest as a verb instead of a noun.** The Framework explores protest as a concept: why it arises, why it fails, its consequences, its moral high ground. A piece that simply rants about something you are angry about is not about protest.
- **Touching the Framework once.** A piece about something else, with one scene of children playing in a park, is not about play. The ideas must be Framework ideas from start to finish.

Thin ideas also cost marks. “Protest is good” and “people should play more” are unexamined. Explore causes, consequences and limits.

Recent Exam Titles

Framework	2024	2025
Protest	Resist and Persist	Small Acts, Big Wins
Personal Journeys	Finding My Way	Changing Direction
Play	Time to Play	Life Is a Game
Country	Connections	Origins

Titles are short (one to four words) and the visuals have increasingly been graphics that suggest ideas rather than photographs that invite a story.

Forms That Have Worked

Examples published in recent assessment reports show how far form can flex:

- **An advertorial** for a play-based childcare centre (Play, 2024), aimed at parents of preschoolers, with a distinct marketing voice and the title used explicitly.
- **A recipe for protest** (Protest, 2024), using imperatives, varied sentence length, subheadings, historical awareness and a touch of humour.
- **A sectioned reflection** on "Finding My Way" (Personal Journeys, 2024), with four subheadings (chameleon, metamorphosis, mosaic, reminisce), each marking a stage of development.

These are not templates to copy. They show that form should be chosen to sharpen ideas.

Craft Reminders

- **Fluid and hybrid forms.** Blend styles: an opinion piece with a narrative opening, a speech that quotes a song lyric.
- **Subheadings** organise ideas and signal a deliberate structure, and they can mark shifts in time or place.
- **Paragraphs are your choice.** Vary length and number for effect; one paragraph is one extended idea.
- **Watch heavy dialogue.** Long stretches of colloquial first-person dialogue tend to flatten complex ideas.
- **Consider audience and context** even though you cannot state them: who is reading, when and where, and what do they already believe?
- **Practise unseen.** Every practice piece from now should use a title you have not seen before, timed at 60 minutes, following the reading-time process above.

Practice Stimuli

Stimuli List I

Create a text that incorporates the idea of personal journeys, using the given title. You must include reference to at least one of the following pieces of stimulus in your response. The text should be shaped around a purpose (to express, to explain, to argue, to reflect) and written with an audience in mind.

Writing Task 1

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'Life is a Journey'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *"Life is a journey with problems to solve, lessons to learn, but most of all experiences to enjoy."*

Ritu Ghatourey

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *“Don't know what I want*
> *So don't ask me*
> *'Cause I'm still trying, to figure it out*
> *Don't know what's down, this road*
> *I'm just walking*
> *Trying to see through the rain coming down*
> *Even though I'm not the only one, who feels the way I do”*

Taylor Swift

Writing Task 2

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **‘The Changing Self’**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *“The greatest discovery in life is self-discovery. Until you find yourself, you will always be someone else. Become yourself."*

Myles Munroe

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *“Choose the path you want and take it (And take it)*
> *If you don’t fit the mould, doesn’t matter, go on and break it*
> *Yes, it’s a square peg life in a round hole town*
> *But it all couldn’t be any sweeter*

> *You may be upside-backwards and wrong side-down*
> *But it just couldn't feel more completer."*

Kelly Clarkson

Writing Task 3

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'Stories of Self'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *"I want to share my life story and honour my roots."*

Rocco DiSpirito

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *“Wherever I may roam*
> *I will hold fast to my traditions.*
> *My language is my cherished possession*
> *My language is the object of my affection*
> *My precious adornment*
> *My language is my strength,*
> *An ornament of grace”*

Stan Walker

Writing Task 4

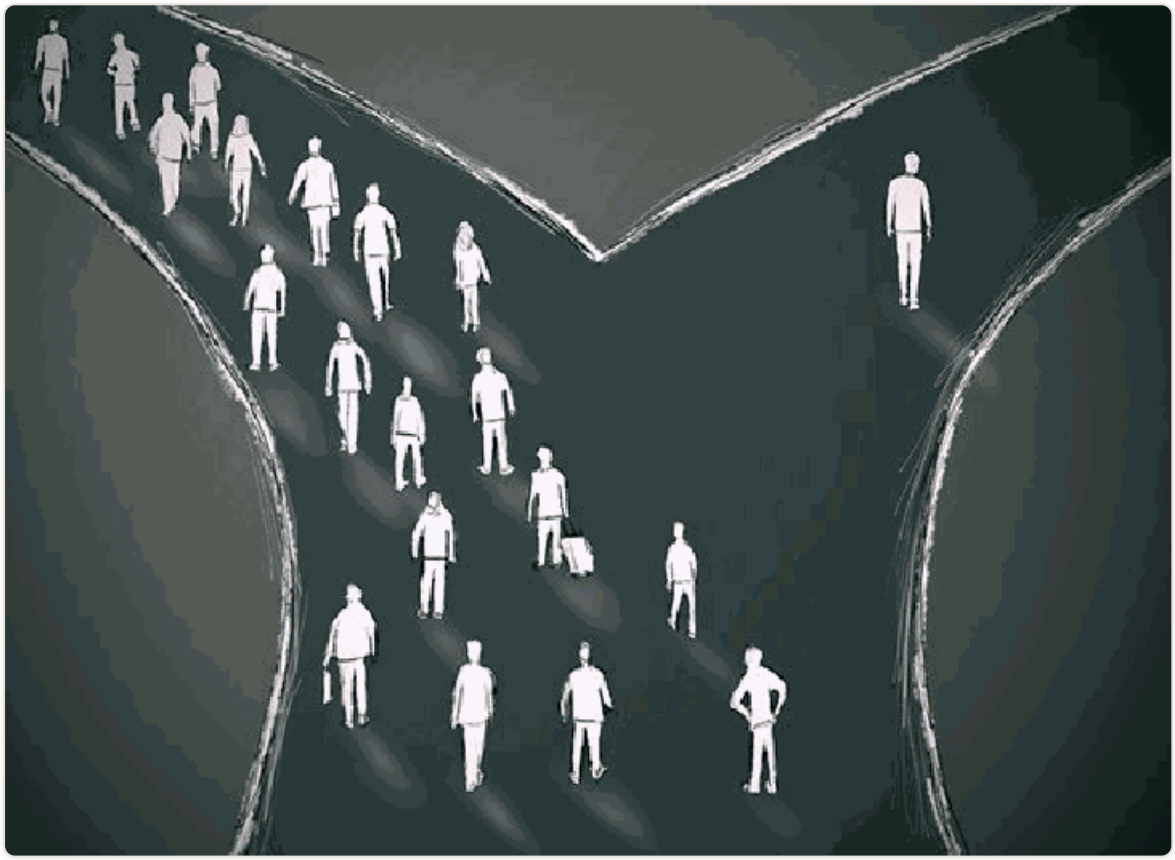
Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **‘Finding Your Own Path’**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *In the rugged expanse of life's rough terrain,*
> *No path laid out, no guiding hand to explain.*
> *Mountains loom tall, a maze to unravel,*
> *Obstacles and messes, chaos to travel.*

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Do not go where the path may lead. Go instead where there is no path and leave a trail."*

Ralph Waldo Emerson

Writing Task 5

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'Getting Lost'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *All is not lost*
> *when your heart*
> *has been shattered.*
> *All is not lost*
> *when you feel so alone.*
> *All is not lost*
> *when your hope*
> *lies in tatters.*
> *This darkness will pass,*
> *keep watching for dawn.*

John Mark Green

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"If you tried and didn't end up where you wanted to go that's still progress."*

Rupi Kaur, Healing Through Words

Writing Task 6

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'A Journey of Transformation'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *Change is natural. Change is one of the only thing we can be certain of: we change constantly; our moods, feelings, and bodies change – change is a part of life and of our everyday existence. We all change over time.*

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Any change, even a change for the better, is always accompanied by discomforts."*

Arnold Bennett

Writing Task 7

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'The Journey Together'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *It doesn't matter where you're going, it's about who you have beside you.*

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *Slowly, slowly*
> *we grow together,*
> *skin across the wound*
> *of our separateness.*

david steinberg

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Sample Creating Texts Piece (19/20)

A high-scoring (19/20) Section B piece written to reflect and express, responding to the title below.

> *Title: 'The Path Less Taken'*

I was at a family dinner over Easter earlier in the year, and one of my aunts asked me a seemingly-innocuous question that made me quite uncomfortable. Usually, I am an upbeat, bubbly person, and most would tell you that I have high confidence. Unfortunately, the opposite is true : every day I question the choices I have made and the impact they have had on my relationships.

When I entered high school, I was faced with a rather uncomfortable choice: I would have to pick a school sport to play during winter, or join a band. The extracurricular lady peered at me over her bifocals , frowning, eyebrows drawn together and raised like little anthills . The only band that had any space was the orchestra, and they needed a piccolo player .

Now, anyone who is acquainted with woodwind instruments would know that the piccolo is a tiny, shrieking version of the flute, and that it should be played only by an experienced flautist with excellent tone. But for a reason unknown both to my parents and myself, I, standing in my oversized blazer with my dress almost at my ankles , boldly offered my services to the school band. The lady in charge of extracurriculars frowned a little harder, and I could almost imagine the tiny ants running in and out of those hills. Then she sat back, sighed, and put my name down, one eyebrow still raised.

Obviously, I was terrible. However, I started practising more and more. I took a certain tormented delight in knowing that while other students were tucking into dinner, or doing a little homework, I was running up and down the same five notes with deliberate focus . As painful as my practice was for all within earshot , the improvement it allowed me in the orchestra gave me surging motivation.

Sometimes in life, you are captured by an idea which is inexplicable to those who haven't felt it. The sense of mastery I felt playing the piccolo made all other subjects at school pale in comparison. What was maths, with all its useless formulae repeated over and over , when music was a space with infinite room for improvement? Where every day's practice contributed to notable growth, however small? Music was not just a hobby for me, but a pursuit which gave me the deepest sense of meaning. Over time, I came to love the piccolo more than anything else.

Unfortunately, as the years went by, my parents, who had initially been in favour of my playing an instrument, slowly started to prioritise other things. I should have been studying more maths, more science, writing more essays. I knew that they expected me to study like my friends, and to aim for medicine so I could become a doctor. As much as I tried, my enthusiasm for those subjects never matched what I felt for music. I practised more, and my grades fell further. I tried to hide reports from my parents (with little success). Finally, when I entered year 12, I committed a cardinal sin: I listed a music degree as my first university preference.

The decision had a negative impact on my parents. Our relationship turned to more fighting, and then stony, awkward dinners . Parents often have high expectations for their children. Life is short. You only buy books for a new highschool year six times with your child, and they only get the ages of 18-22 to do undergrad with people their own age. For parents, not only does time with children fly by, but in many cases the having of children cut their own professional lives short. I remember my mother constantly reminding me that perhaps she would have been so much further ahead in her workplace if not for the family, as much as she loved us . I think for her in particular, the lives of my siblings and myself were vicarious extensions of her own, through which she could live out different "maybe" paths.

You can understand, then, why I would have been so perturbed by my aunt's question: "And what will you be doing at the end of the year?"

For my part, I could never see why my parents were so upset. My three older siblings all left secondary education and diligently commenced medical school. I, on the other hand, could only see one thing: I had one life to live, and I'd rather do anything than spend it dissecting bodies and examining skin conditions. Once you realise that life is short, you come to terms with the fact that you may as well spend it doing things you enjoy. How sad it would be to die doing something you hated out of a feeling of social obligation.

And yet, this is what so many of us do. Many of us end up trapped in degrees, then internships, then grad roles, then middle-management jobs chosen for us by our high-schooler selves, with extremely little experience to guide the decision . Most people enter this life because it is the socially acceptable thing to do, and also because it is extremely difficult to find direction. Artists, inventors, and scientists have to bet against conventional wisdom to pursue their innate dreams. However, conventional wisdom is usually right (which is why we call it wisdom), and so if you don't have a good reason to ignore it, you probably shouldn't. Perhaps, given how much I know my parents care about me, I do understand their worry after all.

So when my aunt asked me this question, the mood in the room dropped somewhat. I thought carefully about my response. Should I lie, tell her that I'll be doing medicine too? Should I say I was prevented by my poor grades? It was almost true . But then I felt the weight of the truth settle upon me, and it was heavy and liberating all at once . I was different. Who cared? This was my life. "So, then? Will you be following your good older siblings?"

"You know, aunty," I twirled some spaghetti around my fork . "I've decided to walk the path less taken."

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Sample Creating Texts Piece: ‘Finding My Way’ (10/10)

A full-mark Personal Journeys piece responding to the title ‘Finding My Way’.

> *Stimuli used: a pair of feet on asphalt with painted arrows pointing in many directions; ‘The caterpillar transforms without thought. Its journey to a beautiful butterfly, inevitable. Why must my own metamorphosis be shaped by so many choices?’*

I remember the day that I got off the plane so vividly. I remember the sun that day, a cruel god beating down upon me from its court of cloudless blue . It scorched my skin and left no prisoners. It was nothing like the benevolent sun over my homeland of Calcutta, where the gentle rays of morning would shine over the backs of a hundred thousand people, wrapped up in their idiosyncratic lifestyles since twilight .

But there was no one here. There was just me, my father, and the red earth that stretched out before me in every direction, desolate and uninviting. My father, a self-titled opportunist, yearning to abandon the stagnancy that is the defining characteristic of the Indian middle class, saw Laxmi, the Hindu goddess of prosperity, hidden in every crack of the drought-stricken land.

I always thought my father was a little bit of an oddball. His brain was rattled around by the many, many wars it had been exposed to. In the same spirit, his nervous yet paradoxically poised energy set our house alive. It would wake up with the soft, repetitive chants of his Sanskrit prayers in the morning and fall asleep to his many lectures about the ideal governmental system come nightfall. It smelled like incense, asafoetida, and cumin, instead of the burnt smoke of the great Australian outback outside our porch door. It was the only piece of home in a strange new country. I cherished it with all my heart.

He was quick to find his way. In three years’ time, he was listening to The Beatles whilst fortifying himself with double helpings of Milo and Bengali egg fry, perusing an assortment

of Hindi newspapers he got internationally delivered to us. The blokes at his sheep shearing job liked to alternate between calling him African and Indigenous Australian, slurs for both inclusive. He paid no heed, jovially punctuating his latest tales of workplace discrimination with, "Their stones and sticks can only rattle my bones! In Calcutta, we used gulel when we really wanted to hurt someone." I didn't have the heart to quip about his idiomatic misquoting. His spirit was indomitable. Nothing could faze him.

I, on the other hand, could not extricate myself from the diminishing gazes of my peers. Every remark on the failure of my foreign tongue to mold itself to the valleys and troughs of a new language, every question underpinned by perfunctory distaste, every snigger swirled in my head each night, consuming the liminal space between waking and sleeping . The movies I watched, the songs I liked, the food I ate, all underwent a strict metamorphosis like the caterpillar confined within the fecund dark of a chrysalis . Slowly, one choice at a time, aligning more and more with the Australian lifestyle. Slowly, one choice at a time, departing from my roots.

That was, until the diagnosis. "Hepatitis B," the doctor called it, the only bloke in town willing to look at a 'coloured' patient. "From infected needles, or maybe passed down in the womb from his mother." My father, try as he might, could not pronounce the name of the illness eating his liver alive. He jokingly called it a gift from our motherland . Over the next few months, I watched him disintegrate into a shell of himself. He could barely open his eyes most days, and when he could, he would talk. He would rasp his smooth tenor into a small tape recorder into the early hours of the morning, flitting from English to Hindi to Bengali as the disease continued its unending assault into his being.

When they complained to me, he laid his papery, wizened hand, which once, in a bygone era, would emanate vitality so potent it was palpable in his air, upon my shoulder and looked at me in the eye with a desperate so intense I felt it in my very soul. "You must find your way, beta. You must tell my story before my time is up."

When he passed, I lost the only person rooting for me, both on this side of the Indian Ocean and the one where I came from. I was lost without him . I felt stagnant, stuck. Our house suddenly felt as desolate as the golden land on my very first day. Over time, I have found my way. I honour his memory by telling his extraordinary story to anyone that will listen. I continue his tradition by hanging his portrait above my mantel and pestering my eldest daughter to hang a garland of fresh marigolds underneath it every morning , just as my father did with his father's portrait, and how his father would have done with his father before him.

Because of him, I have spent a lifetime working as a social worker, aiding those fragmented because of migration , granting me the insurmountable pleasure of listening to a thousand stories . Many of them are like my father and I's, each marked with their own anecdotes and idiosyncrasies. People, struggling, trying, grappling with making sense of a new world. I see the glint of my father's smile in the face of a stranger coming to Australia to make a better life for themselves and their families. I hear his voice in their adversities. It feels like home .

What made this a 10/10

Every scene threads the stimuli through fresh sensory imagery, recurring motifs, and a quiet, honest voice. That layering is what lifts a Section B piece from competent to top band.

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Sample Creating Texts Piece: ‘This is Me’ (10/10)

A full-mark Personal Journeys piece responding to the title ‘This is Me’.

> *Stimuli used: ‘Life isn’t about finding yourself. Life is about creating yourself.’; ‘My story is ready. There’s enough to share. As I have made plenty. Come, sit at my table. Listen and learn. And you will see me.’*

"Good evening customers. Your next service to depart from Platform 2 will be the four-fifty-six Flinders Street running express from Newport to Footscray, Footscray to North Melbourne, and then stopping all stations to Flinders Street. Always remember to touch on your Myki at the start of your journey." The train announcer’s voice is a worn chime, filling the stark station like a frayed tapestry in an abandoned household. The station smells like it always does, redolent with the acrid tang of piss, sweat, and smoke. There is something self-righteous about the smell of a train station; none are exempt from its slightly carcinogenic, slightly metallic embrace .

A low mechanical groan swells beneath his feet as the train approaches, its headlights cutting through the dimness of the already-darkening winter sky with a tired reluctance. The doors slide open with a hydraulic sigh. He steps inside. The 4:56 pm train from Newport Station on Wednesday , the 20th of August, the 2025th year of the Common Era is almost deserted.

He looks down at his hands, admiring the soft webbing connecting the valleys between his fingers. His calluses are peeling, revealing the angry red of new skin underneath. It distantly reminds him of the animal documentaries he used to watch as a kid. He recalls his grandfather teaching him about the rattlesnakes as they appeared on their family’s old LCD; how their cyclical shedding of skin added a new segment to their rattles. Each interlocked and keratinised bit of memory ultimately conjoined to create their characteristic rattles, allowing them to alert nearby friends or warn foe when shook. He

feels a bit like that rattlesnake now, shedding another layer of him, who he was (is?), as his sole ward against something bigger than him.

He straightens, instinctively brushing his hands against the worn fabric of his jeans, as though he can rid himself of that thin, flaking skin, of the evidence that he is still stuck in the process of becoming something else.

The carriage is quieter than he expects. Subdued, like a room where the conversation has only just ended and the last spoken consonant lingers. A man in a hi-vis vest dozes with his head tilted back, mouth slightly ajar and a tenuous string of drool tracing its way down the contours of his jaw. Two teenagers sit across from one another, sharing a set of earbuds, their heads bowed together in conspiratorial symmetry . The girl in green does not look up . He takes a seat by the window.

As the train lurches forward, the station recedes into abstraction. The steel beams dissolve into streaks of grey, then into nothing at all. He watches his reflection instead. It hovers faintly against the glass, superimposed upon the passing city: a face that feels both intimately his and faintly unfamiliar . The train gathers speed.

But at the city, the carriage doors part and the world rushes in. The platform is dense with motion. He takes note of the sudden layering of language, the multiplicity of accents folding over another like tenuous silk organza of his mother's sarees. Someone coughs sharply; someone else argues into a phone; a group of schoolboys with reckless affection. The air smells of coffee, of baked bread, and of the faint tang of iron from the rails.

He lingers. He feels it again, that distance . Not exclusion, really, but a kind of peripheral existence. As though he is still watching the city through the glass when in reality, he's out in the cold, the gale lashing unforgivingly like a whip against his face. He looks down at his hands, at the peeling skin, scrutinising the rawness beneath. Shedding, again. Becoming, again.

He steps off the train and follows the crowd instinctively, letting the current of its movement take him toward Queen Victoria Market. It is not the quiet barter of daytime commerce that he expected. Tonight, the market radiates luminous against the winter chill, illuminated by strings of fairy lights and the glow of fire pits. The scents are the first to hit him: the rich spices from the steaming laksa, sweet smoke from grilled takoyaki, and the inviting swirl of mulled wine and spiced Milo in ceramic mugs held tight between gloved hands.

Luxuriating in the sensory overload, he moves deeper into the market. He spots Hungarian chimney cakes next to Malaysian satay, Latin American empanadas beside Turkish gozleme; the diversity of flavour becoming a rare map of the world in itself, condensed into the congested borders of one crowded laneway. At a food stall selling steaming xiaolongbao, an older man smiles at him and nods, the gesture small but genuine. The delicate crows feet of his smile remind him of his grandfather, the passionate twinkle in his eye as he taught the young boy before him, so many moons ago.

Suddenly trapped in the fossilised resin of memory, he remembers his grandfather's parting words to him, "Life isn't just about finding yourself, beta. You must remember to listen to the stories around you." He nods back to the older man, a little bit awkwardly , but finally laden with the understanding that had eluded him prior .

He realises, watching the ebb and flow of the throng, locals and newcomers, laughter and music, old and young, all engaged in the shared act of eating, moving, and breathing as one under the winter light, that belonging is not a singular destination . It is a mosaic of interactions, layered and overlapping, like the rattles on the snake's tail. Distinct segments forming something whole, something enduring .

He leaves the market with nothing in his hands, but a warmth settled somewhere in his throat. A loosening, however slight, of the tight, invisible vice of unfamiliarity.

The next evening, he boards the 4:56 again. The carriage is fuller now, or perhaps he is simply noticing more. A conversation drifts across the aisle, punctuated by laughter. As the train comes to a grinding halt, someone shifts to make space without being asked . He catches his reflection in the window. It is still there, sullen and superimposed against the speeding city. However, the edges have softened. The distance, though not demolished, has narrowed into something traversable. This is me, he thinks.

"Now arriving at Flinders Street Station..." The train announcer's voice is a worn chime and the station smells like it always does, like piss and sweat and smoke, but this time, he does not flinch . He listens instead, as the city moves with him, no longer a current he moves against , but something he is, slowly, learning how to inhabit.

What made this a 10/10

Every scene threads the stimuli through fresh sensory imagery, recurring motifs, and a quiet, honest voice. That layering is what lifts a Section B piece from competent to top band.